

Vietnamese Spring rolls

This recipe is typically served instead of egg rolls or fried spring rolls, and it is very refreshing as such. But the opportunity is there if you care to fry half your rolls, for example, and present them alternately with uncooked rolls. Try one and see if you like this method. Lightly coat a medium frying pan with vegetable oil and heat to medium-high. Fry rolls for about 1 minute on each side or until lightly browned. Drain on paper towels and serve warm.

Most important: Clear your space and organize all the ingredients ahead of time. These rolls are works of art. Take your time. Accept your mistakes. Relish the beauty of your successes and use the time to meditate as you prepare this recipe.

Easy tips and techniques: read this first

The quantities in this recipe will vary to such a degree that you must make this recipe to see how much you will need or use. Trying to follow strict guidelines will only create frustration. Follow the quantity guidelines and you will have no problems, except maybe some leftovers that can be used in a stir-fry or scrambled eggs.

The ingredients list can be taken as a guideline too. Think about adding or substituting blanched snow peas, sun-dried tomatoes, cooked beets, or any other appropriate item you might find appealing.

Rice paper is somewhat fragile. I usually throw away several cracked and broken sheets before I even get started. However, you may be lucky and buy a package where they'll all be perfect. (Be sure to let me know if this happens.)

If my first few experiences are any indication, you will probably tear a few rice paper sheets as you are rolling them. Hence, I will not even guess how many you will need and suggest you just buy a package.

1 small carrot, peeled and cut into thin slivers

2 teaspoons olive oil

4 large fresh shiitake mushrooms, stems removed, caps cut into thin slivers

1 package dried rice noodles (about 16 ounces) [300g]

1 package rice papers measuring 8½ to 9 inches round (usually 20 rice papers per package) [22 to 23cm]

½ red bell pepper, cut into thin slivers

½ yellow bell pepper, cut into thin slivers

½ medium-small cucumber, peeled, seeded, and cut into thin slivers

½ package (6 to 8 ounces) baked tofu, cut into matchsticks [250g]

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1 bunch of fresh basil

1. **Blanch** the carrot slivers in a medium saucepan of boiling water for 30 seconds or so, until just barely tender. Using a small strainer or slotted spoon, remove the carrot pieces and rinse under cold water until cooled. Drain and set aside.
2. Heat the olive oil in a medium nonstick skillet. Add the shiitakes and **sauté** over high heat, tossing, until just tender, 2 to 3 minutes. Drain on paper towels.
3. Add about ⅓ package of rice noodles to a saucepan of boiling water. (You will need about 1 ounce [30g] noodles per roll.) **Remove** from the heat and let stand for 1 minute, or until the noodles are soft. Drain and rinse in cold water until cooled. Drain again and set aside.
4. Fill a large, shallow bowl with cold water. **Soak** 1 sheet of rice paper at a time in the water for 1 to 2 minutes, or until soft. If the edges are still firm, use your fingertips to gently press the edges until they soften. Carefully lift out the rice paper and let drip for a few seconds over the bowl. Place on a clean cutting board. Before you begin to assemble your roll, place another rice paper in the water so it will be ready when you are finished with the current one.
5. Set a small mound of noodles (about 1 ounce [30g]) 2 inches [5cm] from the bottom of the rice paper. Leave a 1- to 1½-inch [3- to 4-cm] margin on the sides. **Top** the noodles with one-tenth of the carrots, mushrooms, peppers, cucumbers, and tofu. After the first roll or two, you will realize how much is too much or too little. Season with salt and pepper to taste.
6. **Fold** the sides up over the filling and carefully begin to roll the rice paper up from

the bottom. After one turn of the paper, add 1 or 2 basil leaves (they will show through the translucent paper) and continue to roll into a tight cylinder.

7. **Roll** the paper all the way over, and the paper will stick to itself—more so as it begins to dry. Your finished product should be about 4 to 5 inches [10 to 12cm] long. Set aside on a large plate and repeat with the remaining rolls. Cover and refrigerate if not eating right away, up to 3 hours. If fried, they're best eaten while still warm.

chef's serving suggestions Serve with Orange-Sesame Dipping Sauce, Chinese Mustard Dressing, Sweet and Sour Sauce (recipes follow), or the peanut sauce in Charney's Classic Peanut Sauce (page 124). If you have time, make two or more sauces. A choice of dips makes for an excellent presentation.

SERVES 5

